

Quantifying the Illicit Ecosystem of Online Betting Apps

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Online Betting is now a multi-billion dollar global Industry

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‘Third Largest Economy’—\$5.9 Trillion Gambling Beyond Regulation

By [Boaz Sobrado](#), Contributor. © Boaz Sobrado is a fintech leader and... ▾

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Online Betting is now a multi-billion dollar global Industry

- Sports, Casino, Fantasy and Prediction Games



Online Betting is now a multi-billion dollar global Industry

- Sports, Casino, Fantasy and Prediction Games
- Smartphones + cheap internet (mobile data) has made betting available to anyone, any time

Online Betting is now a multi-billion dollar global Industry

- Merged with Influencer culture and short-form video

rest of world / Africa



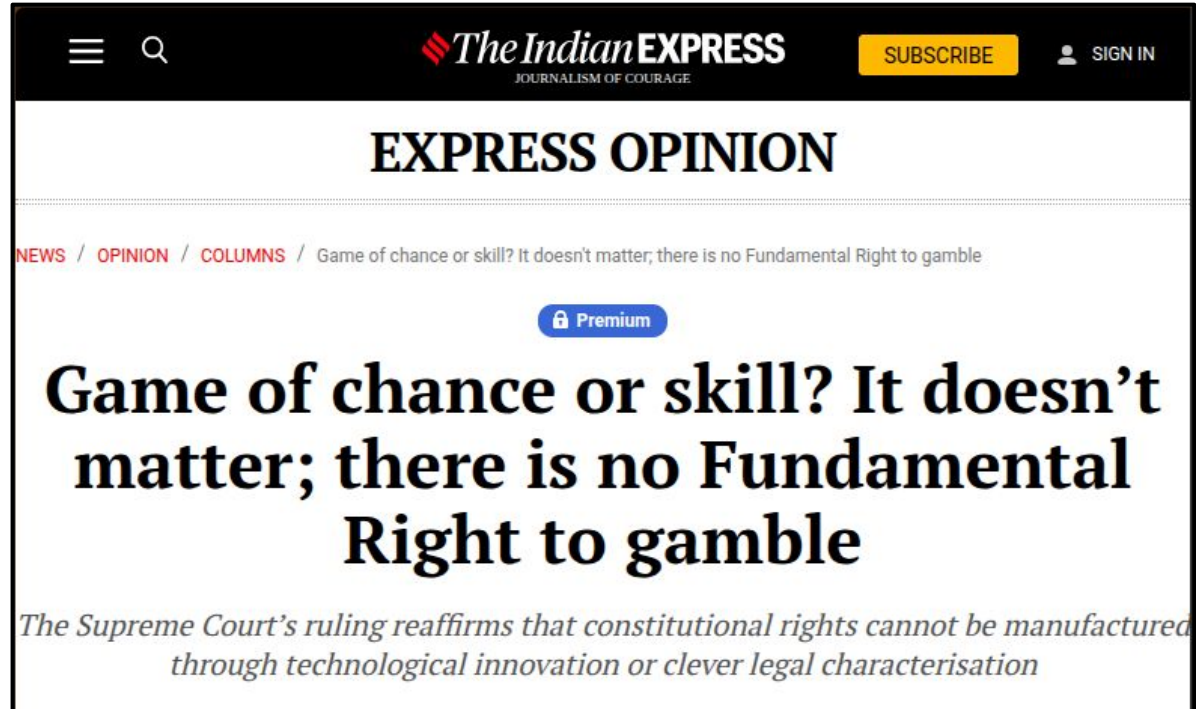
MONEY

Influencers are getting young Nigerians hooked on online gambling

While sports betting is legal in Nigeria, experts say the government should have more oversight on the influencer culture.

Online Betting is now a multi-billion dollar global Industry

- Many products sit in a legal grey zone (“game of skill”, offshore operators, surrogate brands)



Why is this a Problem?

- Public-health reporting links these apps to financial loss, addiction issues, debt stress and in some cases loss of life.



Spotlight

Online Sports Betting Hits Social Feeds—But Not Evenly, New NORC Study Finds

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Authors

[Soubhik Barari](#)
[Alex Kresovich](#)
[Sherry Emery](#)



March 2026

An analysis of users' data from TikTok, Facebook, and Instagram finds 10 percent of users saw about 50 percent of all gambling content.

Ask NORC

< [Working Papers](#)

Gambling Away Stability: Sports Betting's Impact on Vulnerable Households

Scott R. Baker, Justin Balthrop, Mark J. Johnson, Jason D. Kotter & Kevin Pisciotta

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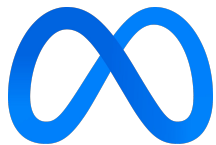
We estimate the causal effect of online sports betting on households' investment, spending, and debt management decisions using household transaction data and a staggered difference-in-differences framework. Following legalization, sports betting spreads quickly, with both the number of participants and frequency of bets increasing over time. This increase does not displace other gambling or consumption but significantly reduces savings, as risky bets crowd out positive expected value investments. These effects concentrate among financially constrained households, as credit card debt increases, available credit decreases, and overdraft frequency rises. Our findings highlight the potential adverse effects of online sports betting on vulnerable households.

Quantifying the betting app ecosystem

- Complete cross-platform lifecycle
- From user recruitment —————> harms they experience.

Our Approach

Link Promotion and Downstream user experience

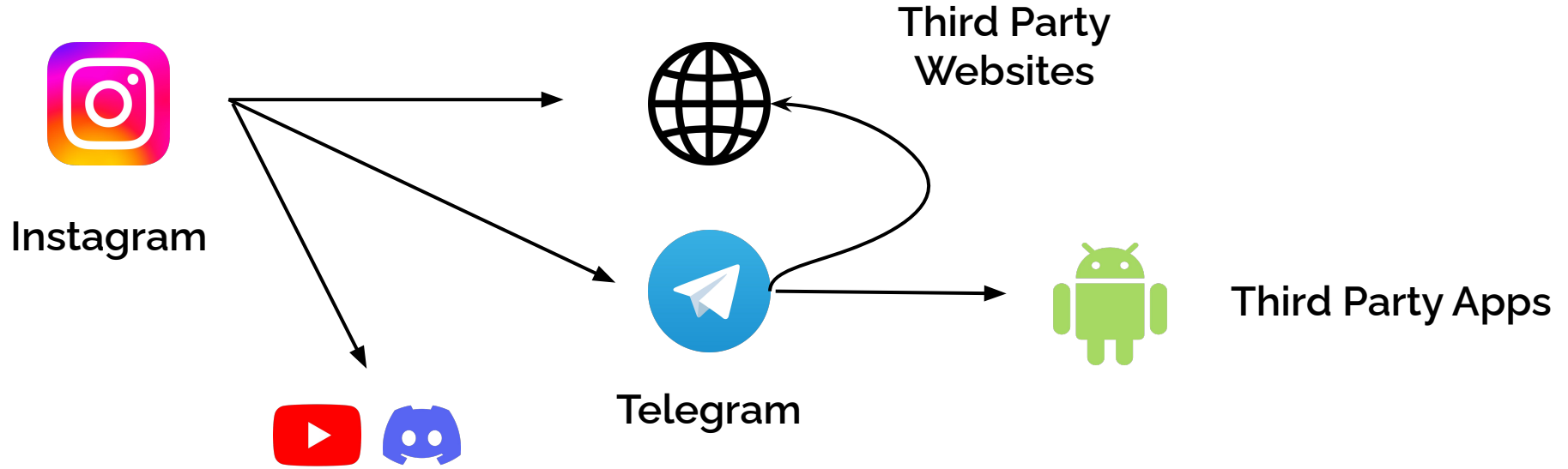


Paid Promotion

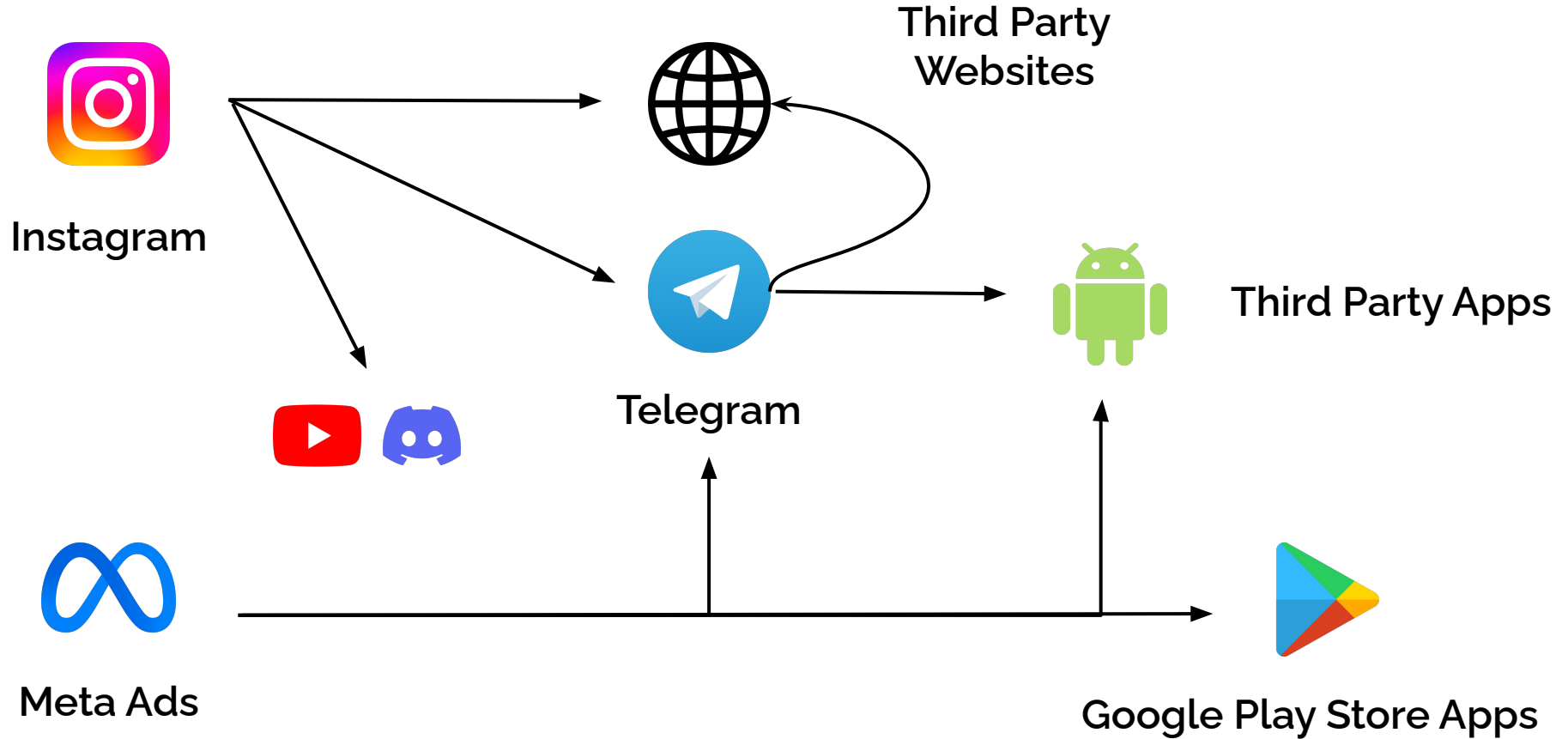


Organic /Semi-Organic
Promotion

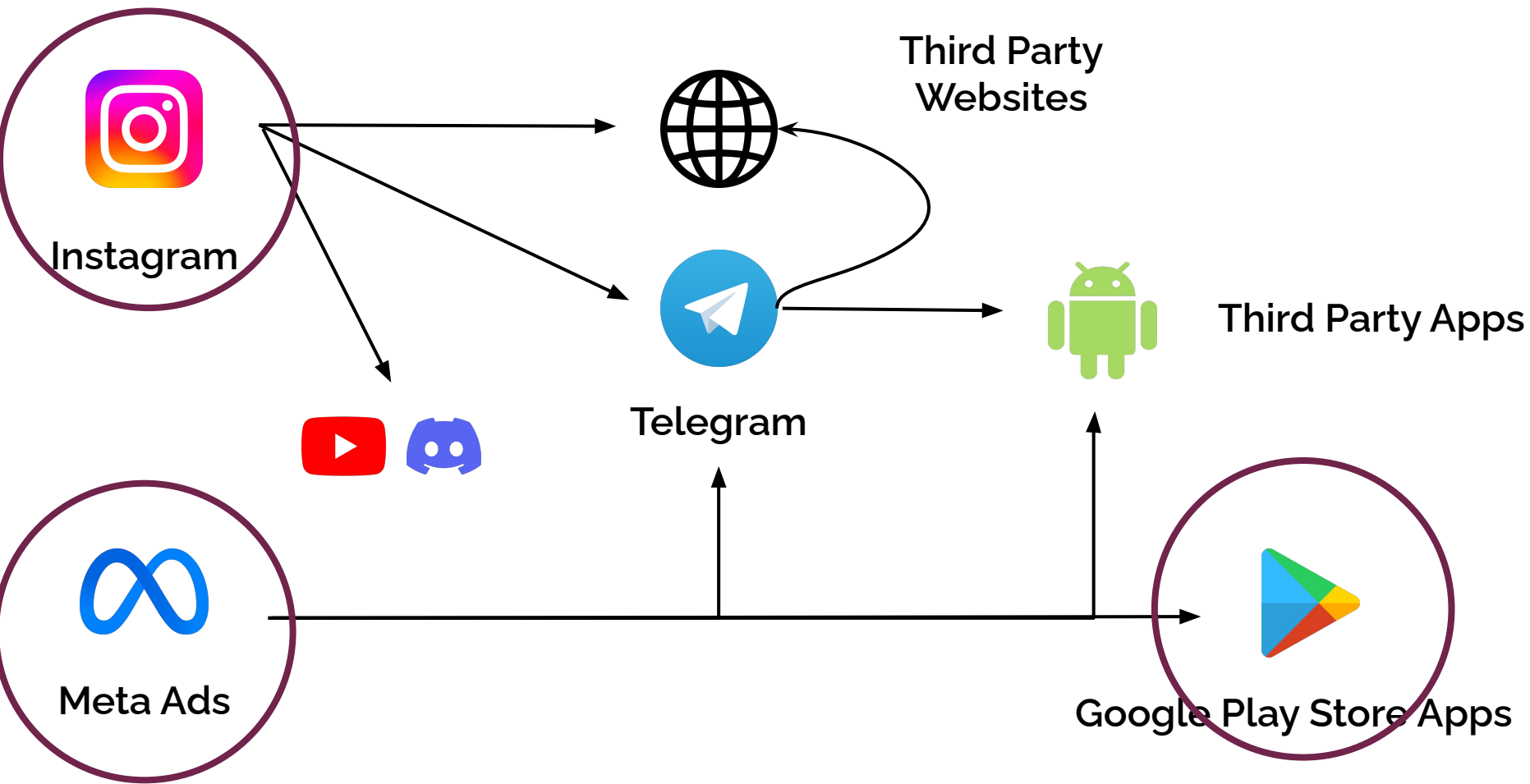
Our Approach



Our Approach



Our Approach



Our Approach

Link Promotion to Downstream user experience

Meta Ads

Paid Ads
Meta Ad Library

~**23,600** from
2023-2025

Instagram Posts

Organic Posts
Public Instagram
content from
betting-linked
hashtags

~**2,700** posts

Play Store Reviews

Google PlayStore user
reviews of the betting
apps these
promotions link too

~**330,000** one ★
reviews

What does the promotion on Meta say?

- We wanted to understand the harm posed to the user from a Ad.
- We applied an **inductive coding** methodology to annotate the entire dataset of ~22,600 advertisements

What does the promotion on Meta say?

Ad Category

Messaging Strategy

Potentially Harmful Themes

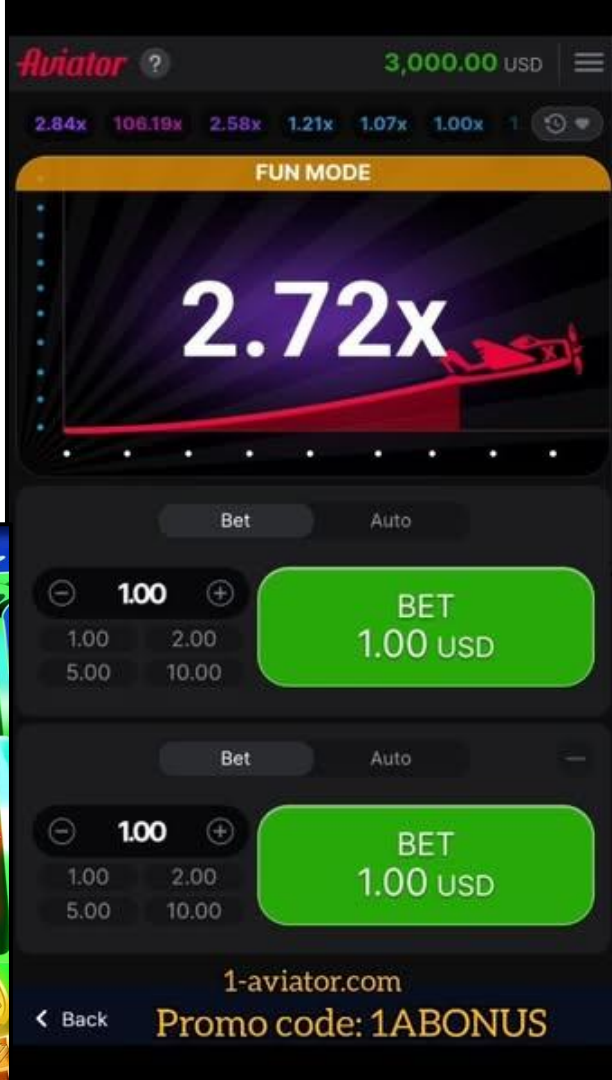
Media Authenticity

Sexual Content

What does the promotion on Meta say?

Ad Category

- Sports Betting
- Casino Games
- Trading/ Crypto
- Prediction Games



What does the promotion on Meta say?

Messaging Strategy

- User Acquisition



USE PROMO CODE
TANZANIA07

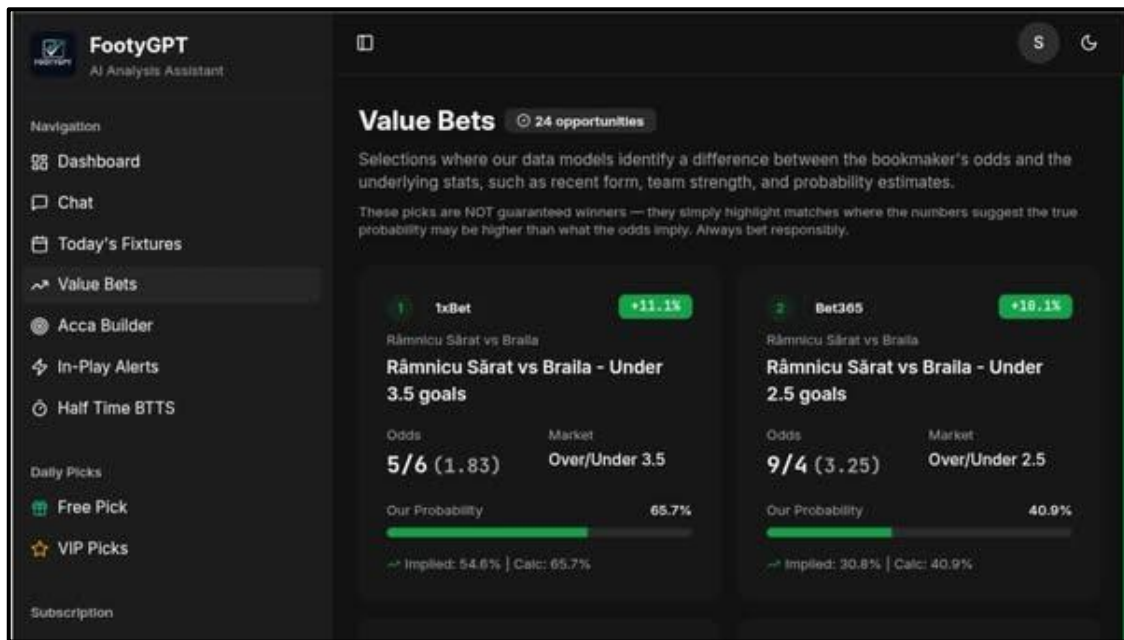
AND GET A 200%
WELCOME BONUS.

BETWINNER

What does the promotion on Meta say?

Messaging Strategy

- User Acquisition
- Promoting a Feature



What does the promotion on Meta say?

Messaging Strategy

- User Acquisition
- Promoting a Feature
- Misleading or Deceptive

04.04.25 / FRIDAY WWW.ROCKN'CASH.COM #795352186563

TOP • NEWS

JACKPOT • LAST CHANCE • BRAND-NEW • SPECIAL OFFER

• LIVE



3,000,000 FREE COINS

CLAIM NOW

BREAKING NEWS

RNC LAUNCHES NEW OFFER

Success at Rock N' Cash Casino does not imply success at real money gambling and gaming



What does the promotion on Meta say?

Messaging Strategy

- User Acquisition
- Promoting a Feature
- Misleading or Deceptive
- Social Proof / Testimonials



What does the promotion on Meta say?

Potentially Harmful Themes

- Easy Money

FUSSBALL TIPPS MIT KI



Manchester City

1 : 1

Endstand



Chelsea

KI SCHLÄGT DEN BUCHMACHER

Quote: 8,0	€ 170
Éinsatz:	€ 1.360

- ✓ 96 % Erfolgsquote - getestet und bewiesen.
- ✓ IA erledigt die Afbeit, du kassierst die Gewinne.
- ✓ Über 11,000 Nutzer vertrauen dieser Technologie

Abonniere unseren Kanal



What does the promotion on Meta say?

Potentially Harmful Themes

- Easy Money



What does the promotion on Meta say?

Potentially Harmful Themes

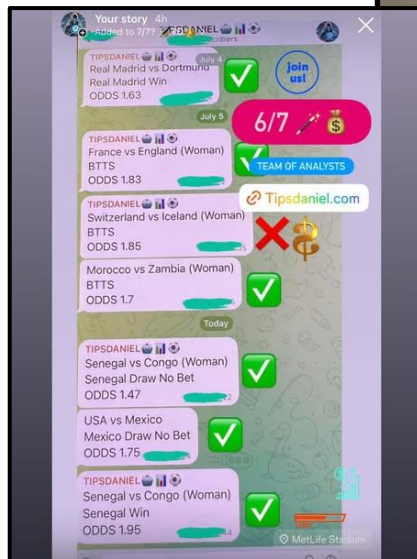
- Easy Money
- Risk Minimization



What does the promotion on Meta say?

Potentially Harmful Themes

- Easy Money
- Risk Minimization
- Income Source Framing



What does the promotion on Meta say?

Potentially Harmful Themes

- Easy Money
- Risk Minimization
- Income Source Framing
- Debt Solution



Arjun Rajput

meenamrinku

2 followers · 0 posts

You follow each other on Instagram

New Instagram account

[View Profile](#)

Today 6:16 AM

Hi sir please Mera loss recover kara do

Sir Mera loss 95k ha sir plz 😞😞😞

Ho jayega cover withdrawal ke bad
40 Commission Dena hoga

Sir ma dal dunga

Sir please link send karo



What does the promotion on Meta say?

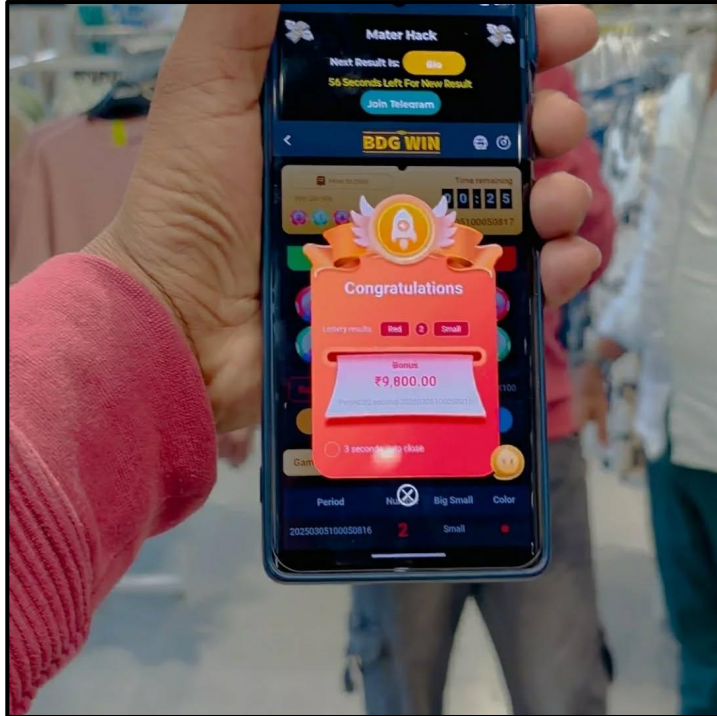
Media Authenticity

- Authentic
- AI generated



Promotion on Instagram

Gemini 2.5 Pro to annotate all Instagram posts



THA7
ONLINE BOOK

SOUTH AFRICA
VERSUS
PAKISTAN

10% WELCOME BONUS

5% REFILL BONUS

1:30 PM - 29TH DEC

DAY 4 - 1ST TEST TOUR OF SOUTH AFRICA

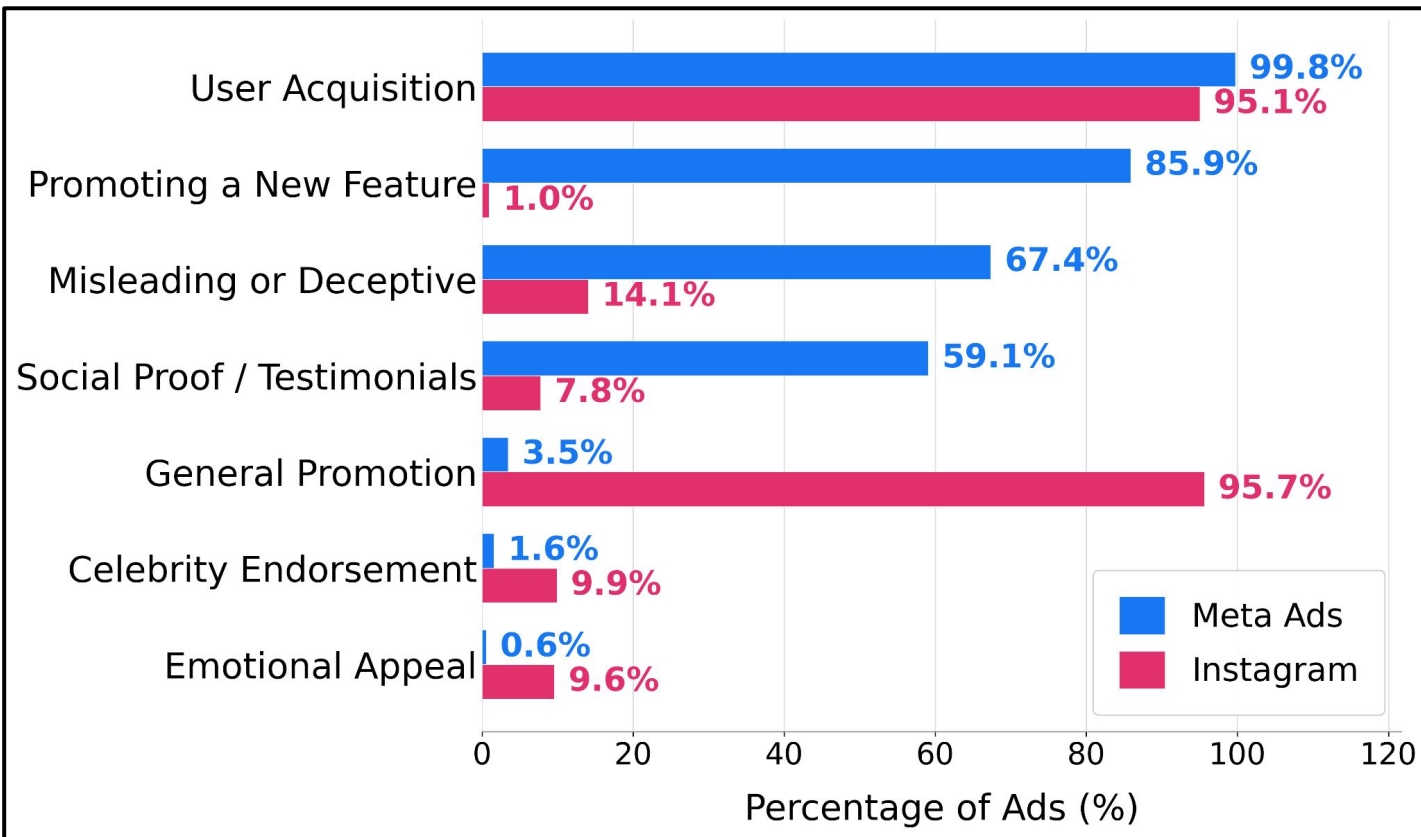
OUR OFFICIAL WEBSITE : WWW.THALA7EXCH.COM

Best Odds Live in Play Easy Deposit Easy Withdrawal

+91 8980133000 | +91 8980344000

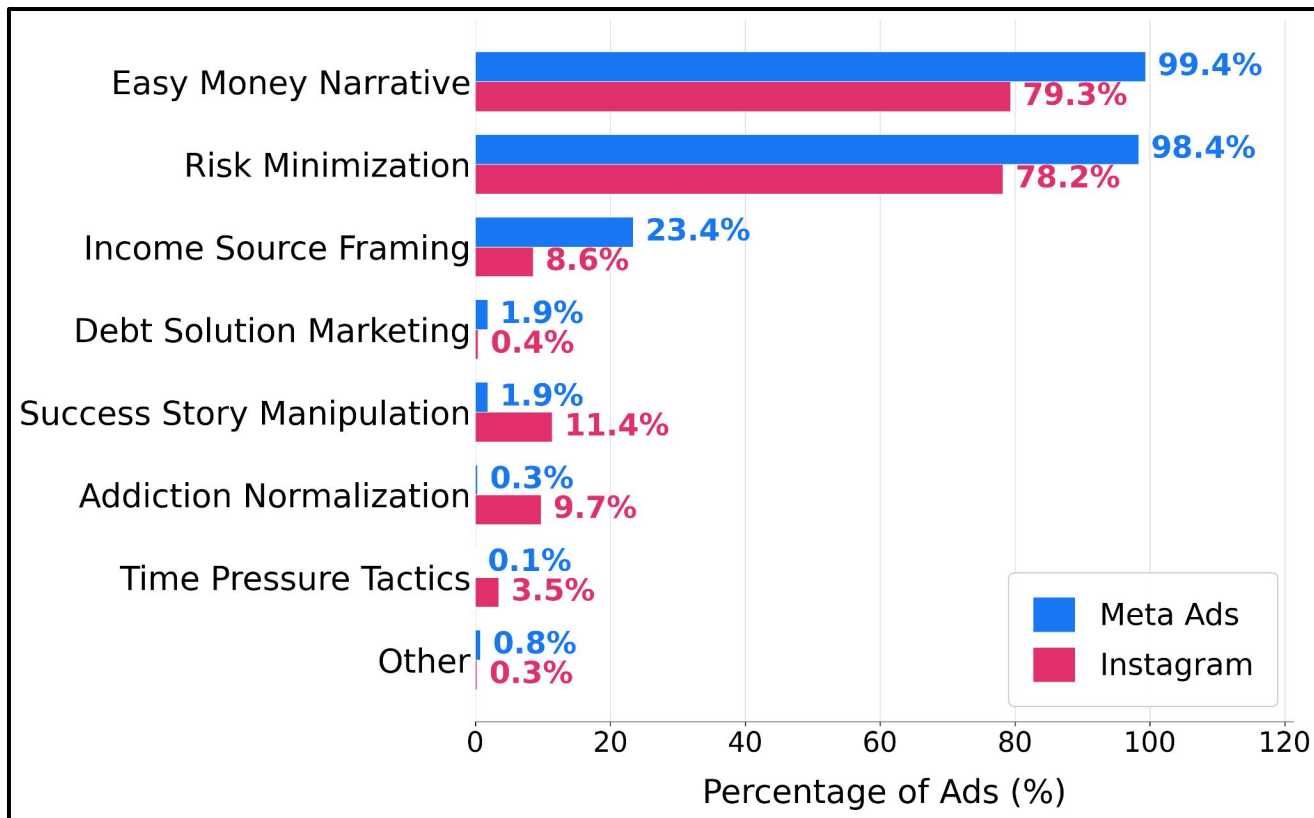
Promotion on Instagram

Gemini 2.5 Pro to annotate all Instagram posts



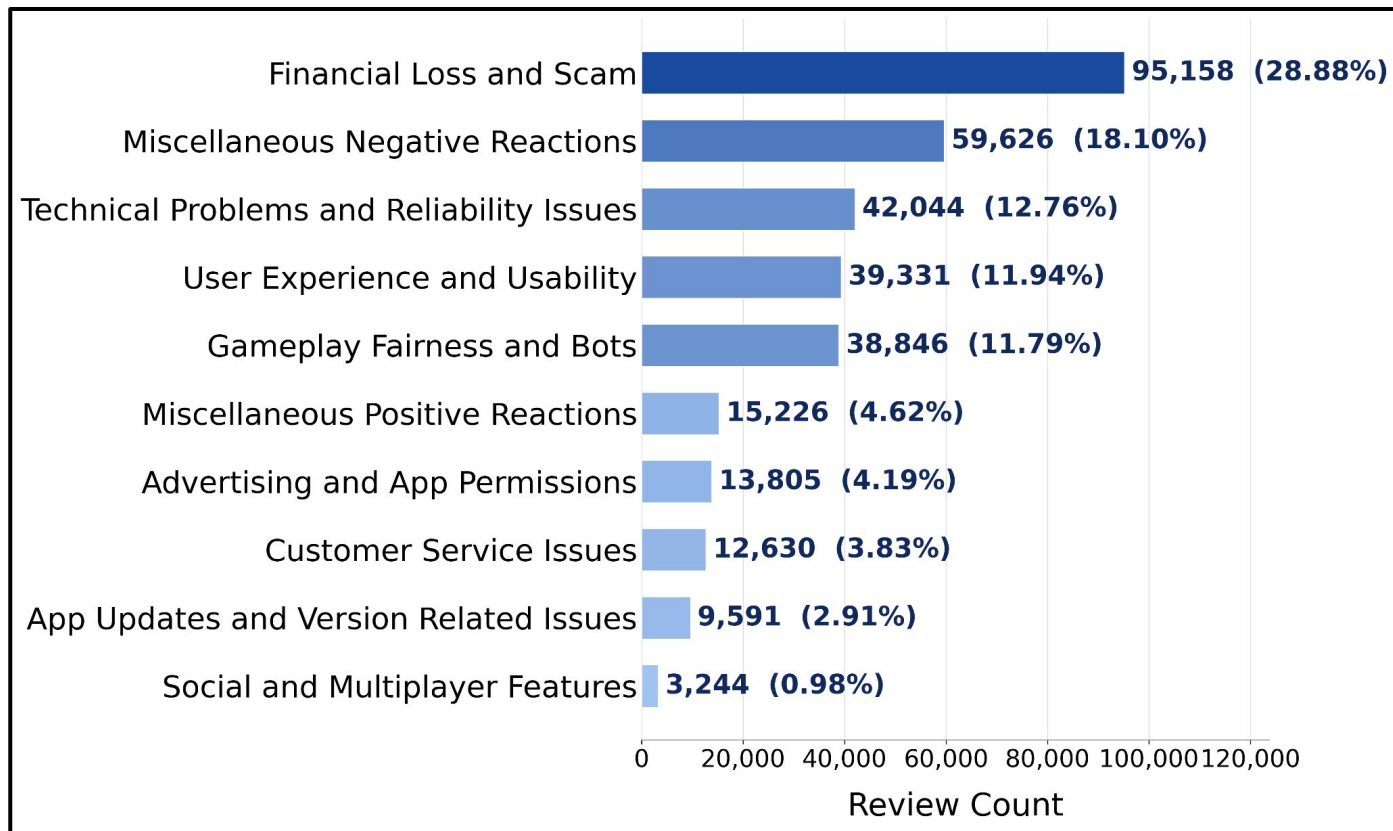
Promotion on Instagram

Gemini 2.5 Pro to annotate all Instagram posts



What Users actually report

Topic Modelling on ~330,000 1 star reviews surfaces user harm



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- Financial loss and perceived scams dominate the complaints.

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What Users actually report

Topic Modelling on ~330,000 1 star reviews surfaces user harm

- Financial loss and perceived scams dominate the complaints.
- Blocked or delayed withdrawals, unclear rules, unresponsive support
- Repeated language of addiction, despair, family strain, and severe distress

“This game sucks the life out of you. It triggers depression.....”

Finding 1

There is a clear discrepancy between what is **promoted** and what is **experienced** by the users

Easy Money - small stakes shown converting into large wins

Risk Minimization - outcomes framed as knowable and predictable

Finding 2

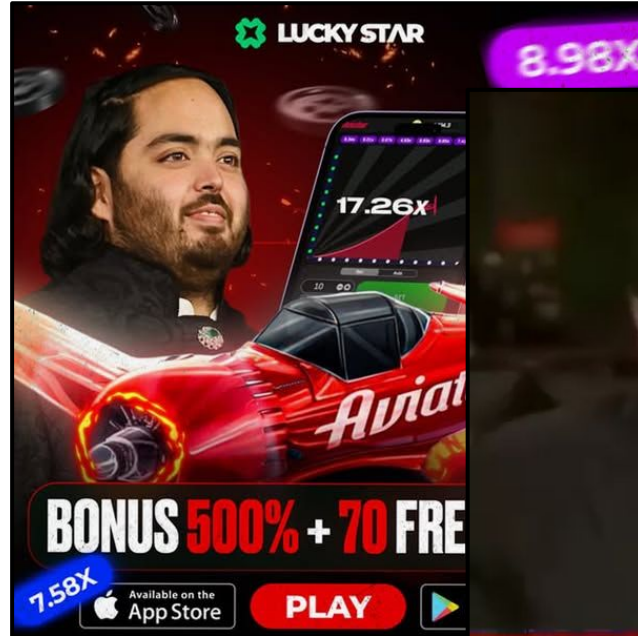
Platform compliance and Region based metadata (transparency gap)

We found 20,591 taken down by Meta at the time on data collection



Finding 3

AI as a Force Multiplier; **14.8%** of ads were AI-generated, used to imply endorsement.



Finding 4

The Shadow Funnel and Regulatory Evasion.

Meta Ads and Instagram content push users to Telegram/third party websites.

Even if Google Play removes a specific betting app, the recruitment infrastructure remains intact on Meta, simply redirecting users to a new domain or a channel

This is not an India problem

Can the same **methodology** be applied to different regions?

This is not an India problem

Can the same **methodology** be applied to different regions?

Meta Ad's found in

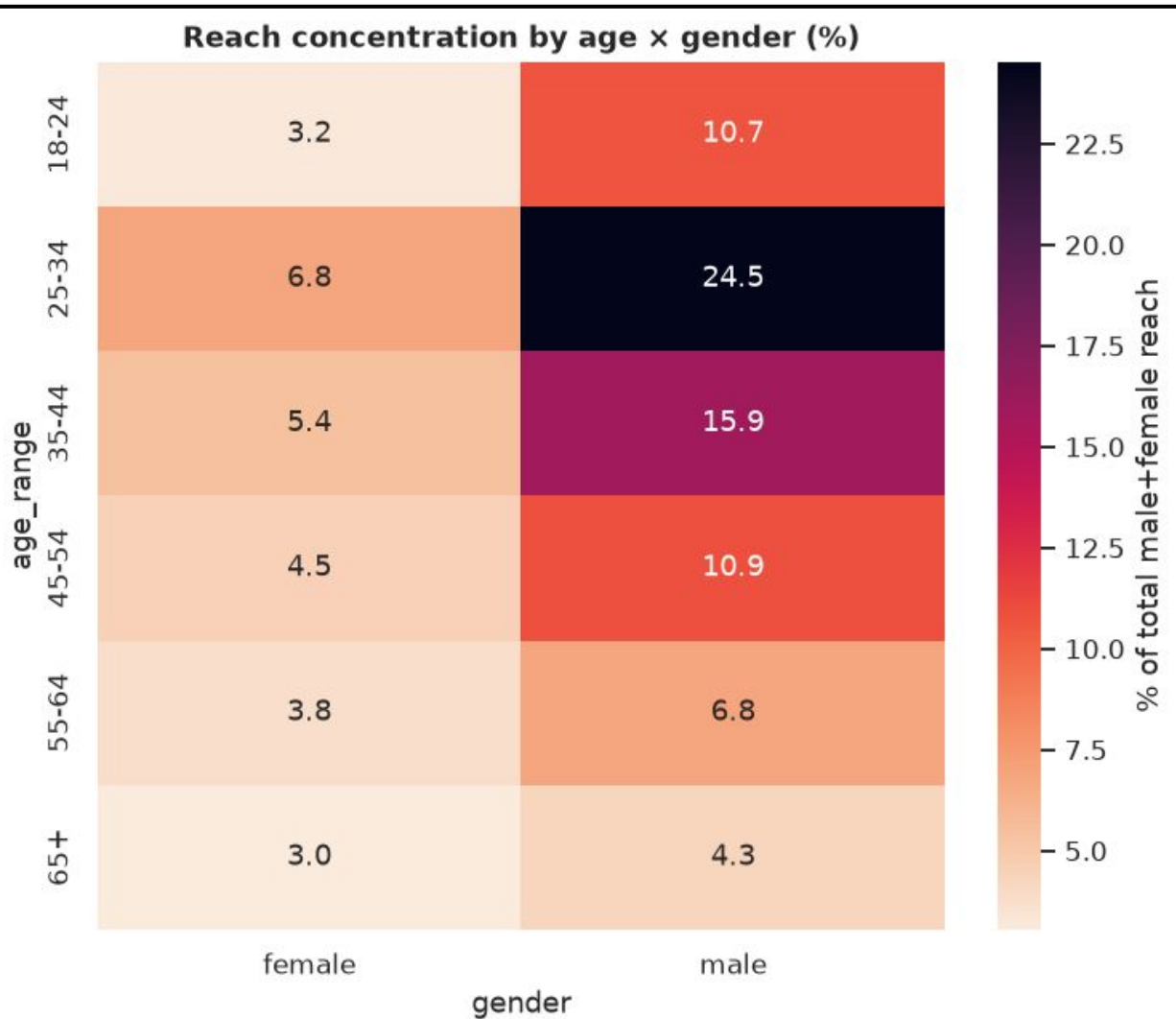
EU: 127,811

UK: 35,553

US: 8,370

Discussion on EU

- 127,811 ads where shown by 7,349 unique pages
- Most ads reached Men and of people from 25-34 age group
- Germany, Italy, Belgium - most targeted countries



US Cable Shows

How **prevalent** is this content on mainstream TV?

CNN, Fox News, MSNBC, CNBC

US Cable Shows

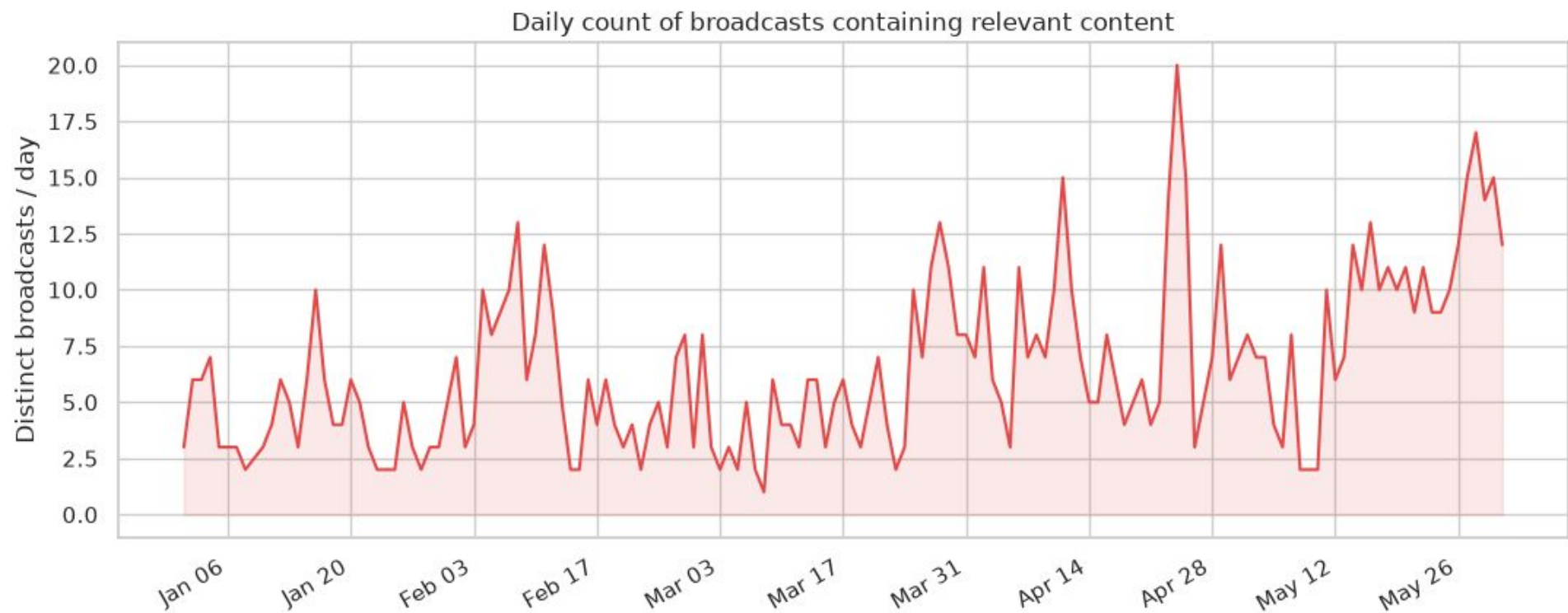
Prediction Markets, Sports Betting, Casino Games

We collected CNN TV shows data from 1st Jan 2026 - 31st May 2026

Editorial Discussion - Commercial/Ads on TV

977 / 3,595 (**27.2%**) broadcasts were detected to contain related content

US Cable Shows



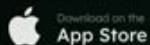
US Cable Shows

Commercials

Kalshi

Trade on anything.

PROMO CODE: **TV** **Get \$10**



\$10 promotion bonus eligible for new customers only, restrictions apply. 18+ only. Restrictions and eligibility requirements apply. Event contract trading involves significant risk and is not appropriate for everyone. Please carefully consider if it's appropriate for you in light of your personal financial circumstances. Actual differ than shown; markets shown in advertisement may not be active. See kalshi.com/regulatory for more information.



Glenns cannot trade on basketball, obviously, 18+ only. Restrictions and eligibility requirements apply. Event contract trading involves significant risk and may not be suitable for all investors. Prices, values, and available markets may differ from those shown. Certain products may not be available in all jurisdictions. For more information see kalshi.com/regulatory

US Cable Shows

Editorial Discussion



US Cable Shows



Thank You!

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